parties have let them down. It has fielded two candidates in MP, in the reserved seats of Ratlam and Dhar, but is making its sharpest inroads in Rajasthan. Here, BAP candidate and Chorasi MLA Rajkumar Roat is in a tight battle against Congress turncoat and BJP candidate Mahendrajeet Malviya in the Dungarpur-Banswara seat in southern Rajasthan. In fact, the current is so strong in some areas, former 'sabhapati' of Dungarpur municipal council and BJP leader K.K. Gupta says, the non-tribal communities feel sidelined here. "We live under constant fear and have almost no representation in any elected body. We either suffer or migrate," he alleges, saying the Sangh's Rajasthan Vanvasi Parishad is not doing enough to counter the BAP here.

What also makes tribal votes crucial in Rajasthan is the 'spillover effect' it has on general seats. For example, Sawaimadhopur Tonk is a general category LS seat but has had a number of MPs from the Meena ST community. In southern Rajasthan too, the tribal influence extends to three more seats other than the reserved ones.

Regional Trails

In other states with sizeable tribal populations, regional forces seem to hold equal sway. In Odisha, the ruling Biju Janata Dal (BJD) has a firm hold over the tribal segments while in West Bengal, it's neck-and-neck between the BJP and the Trinamool Congress (TMC). The BJP won the two reserved LS seats, Alipurduars and Jhargram, in 2019, but the Trinamool Congress (TMC) came back strong in the 2021 assembly polls, winning nine seats in the region. In Jharkhand, the arrest of Chief Minister Hemant Soren could have a bearing in the five ST reserved seats, with a sympathy wave in favour of his wife, Kalpana, and the ruling Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM).

Meanwhile, in the Northeast, the BJP's relationship with the tribals remains complicated. Barring Assam, Manipur and Tripura, tribal populations are a majority in the other five NE states. The current conflict between the Kukis and Meiteis has damaged the party's credibility in the region, but voting patterns among the NE tribals are unlikely to change. Assam and Arunachal, happy with the Modi government's focus on development, are unlikely to shift loyalties. In Manipur, the party is not even contesting the Outer Manipur seat, dominated by the Nagas. Other states will witness contests between the NDA allies and the Congress/regional parties. In Tripura, the BJP has formed a coalition with the Tipra Motha headed by royal scion Pradyot Debbarma who is popular among the tribals.

Interestingly, reactions on the ground, without exception, suggest that issues like the construction of the Ram temple and the abrogation of Article 370 have little resonance among the tribal electorate. Even PM Modi's popularity doesn't seem to be the primary selling point. It's more the TINA factor that will be working for the BJP. The opposition Congress has been trying hard to reclaim its tribal strongholds, with Rahul Gandhi often raising the Adivasi (original settlers) versus the BJP's Vanvasi (forest-dwellers) debate, holding it up as an example of the ruling party's "perverted logic in denigrating the community". It remains to be seen whether such rhetoric will get traction on the ground, considering the ruling party's entrenched organisation network. ■

with Rahul Noronha, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Kaushik Deka, Amarnath K. Menon, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rohit Parihar and Amitabh Srivastava

BJP'S VANVASI PITCH

- ST component in budget hiked from Rs 21,525 crore in 2013-14 to Rs 78,256 crore in 2021-22
- No. of minor forest produce items covered under MSP up from 12 in 2014 to 87 in 2021
- Scholarship budgets up from Rs 978 crore to Rs 2,546 crore (2021-22)
- 500-odd Eklavya schools sanctioned in past 10 years
- Ten tribal museums set up across the country; tribal freedom fighter Birsa Munda birth anniversary, Nov. 15, celebrated as Janjatiya Gaurav Divas

CONGRESS'S ADIVASI SANKALP

- 'Adivasi Nyay' guarantees the protection of water, forests, land rights of tribals
- All amendments made to the Forest Conservation Act and Land Acquisition Act by the BJP government to be rescinded
- Dedicated forest rights division, separate budget to implement Forest Rights Act. All FRA claims to be settled
- Panchayat (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act or PESA will have state laws to protect gram sabhas
- MSP for minor forest produce to get legal status